Everyone Needs More Meaning in Their Life

Marc Alexander · Week 8

1 Meaning and Structure

the meaning part

- *Week 8:* Meaning and the World
- *Week 9:* Meaning and Words
- *Week 10:* Change in Meaning
- *Week 11:* Extending Meaning

2 Meaning and Grammar

- **Closed class words:** pronouns, conjunctions, auxiliary verbs, determiners, prepositions, etc
- **Open class words:** nouns, verbs, adverbs, and adjectives
- The closed classes often carry a **grammatical meaning** ('this is in the future', 'this is definite', 'these things are alternates', 'this is certain', 'this is on top of something else'); these are meanings which function to indicate relationships between open-class words
- The open classes often carry a **lexical meaning**…

3 Lexical Meaning

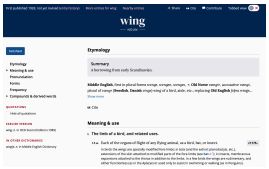


FIGURE 1 The OED Online entry for wing, noun, open at its etymology and first sense



FIGURE 2 The OED Online entry for punch, verb, showing its quotations



FIGURE 3 The OED Online entry for trebuchet, noun, a medieval siege engine



FIGURE 4 The OED Online entry for cloudy, adjective, with its Old English quotations



FIGURE 5 The OED Online entry for Zoom, verb, to communicate by video call, with quotations from 2014 to 2020

> Why study semantics? Semantics (as the study of meaning) is central to the study of communication; and as communication becomes more and more a crucial factor in social organization, the need to understand it becomes more and more pressing. Semantics is also at the centre of the study of the human mind – thought processes, cognition, conceptualization – all these are intricately bound up with the way in which we classify and convey our experience of the world through language.
>
> Leech 1981: ix

> If we ask where the meanings of words exist, the answer must be: in the minds of native speakers of the language.
>
> Saeed 2003: 6

4 How Do Words *Mean*?

- Words – like *banana* – have a relationship between the word as a thing made up of letters and sounds and the thing in the world it refers to.
- Debates about the relationship between words and things take into account:
  1. The *form* of the word (its sound or written image)
  2. The *referent* (the thing to which the word refers)
  3. The *concept* (the mental abstraction which the form articulates)



FIGURE 6 A banana

5 The Semiotic Triangle

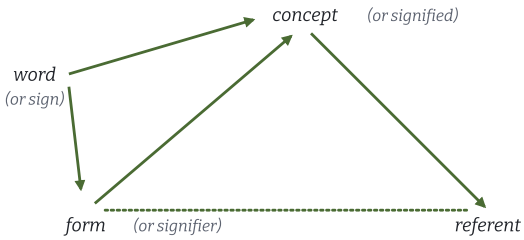


FIGURE 7 The semiotic triangle with the alternative terms: concept (or signified), form (or signifier), word (or sign)

6 Form and Referent

- The relationship between the *form* and the *referent* is a dashed line because there is (usually) **not a direct relationship** between the word's form and its referent



FIGURE 8 A pug sitting on a wooden floor with a paper label reading DOG on its head

- English: *dog*
- Dutch: *hond*
- Finnish: *koira*
- German: *Hund*
- Hawaiian: *ʻīlio*
- Icelandic: *hundur*
- Italian: *cane*



FIGURE 9 A black pug in a patterned harness, looking up at the camera

- Japanese: 犬
- Mandarin: 狗
- Korean: 개
- Arabic: *الكلب*
- Hebrew: *כֶּלֶב*
- Greek: *σκύλος*
- Russian: *собака*

7 *Usually* not a relationship

- Sometimes there *is* a relationship between the two:
  - **Onomatopoeia**, which means the mimicry of a concept by a word, such as *bang, splash, quack*, etc.



FIGURE 10 A comic by James Chapman, How to sound like a duck in 7 languages: quack, rap, mac, háp, coin, vak and praaks

- Sometimes there *is* a relationship between the two:
  - **Phonaesthesia**, which means when words expressing similar concepts share some characteristics of form
  - Many English words referring to a reflection of light from a surface begin with *gl-* (including *glint, glisten, gleam, glitter, glow*)
  - Many words to do with uncomfortable or twisting movement begin with *wr-* (including *writhing, wrenching, wresting, wringing, wreathing, wrying, writher, wriggle, wrinkle*)
  - Many words to do with wetness often begin with *sl-* (including *slurp, slake, slobber, slippery, slime, slop, slush, sludge, slide, sledge, slick, slither, slope, slalom*), etc.

8 How do you define a word?

- Because of the semiotic triangle, we know that we define words by combining a *concept* and a *form*.
- So when confronted with a form, we can refer to the concept by:
  - describing a set of characteristics of the concept, or
  - by pointing to a typical example (this is an *ostensive definition*)
- The concept part of a word does not lie itself in the examples, but through encountering examples we can come up with that concept. (And sometimes update it, as we'll see in week 10.)

9 Finding Examples

- When you give an ostensive definition, what example do you choose?
- Draw a *tree* so that you can use it as an ostensive definition.



FIGURE 11 Dragon's blood tree (*Dracaena cinnabari*)



FIGURE 12 Joshua tree (*Yucca brevifolia*)



FIGURE 13 A broad oak tree standing alone in a green field

- What about a *house*?



FIGURE 14 Wikimedia Commons

10 Prototypes

- How many of you actually live in a house like this?
  - Detached
  - Two stories
  - Smoke coming from a chimney
- How many of you would say things like "I'm going back to the house now" when you mean a flat?
- What is the definition of a *house*?

NOUN

I. A building for habitation, and related senses.

I.1.a. A building for human habitation, typically and historically one that is the ordinary place of residence of a family. (Cf. **home** *n.*[1] A.I.2.)

Sometimes (with capital initial) in the names of individual residences, esp. large mansions or country houses.

With *the*: a person's home.

FIGURE 15 The OED's first definition of house, noun: a building for human habitation, typically and historically one that is the ordinary place of residence of a family

- Shared typical features of a *set* create a *categorisation*
- We do this through our experience of the world as speakers
- But not all members are equally typical of the set
- Central, typical, members of a set are called prototypes
- We can usually get agreement from speakers of a particular variety as to the central members of a set

11 Vegetables

- Write down the first three typical vegetables you can think of
- When this experiment was done with US college students: _____

12 Prototypes

- Prototypes represent categories of sets
- Almost all sets are *fuzzy*
- Items on the edges of a fuzzy set can be arguable:
  - Centre of the set we call *birds*: sparrow, robin, blackbird, crow
  - Edge of the set: ostrich, penguin
  - Share some characteristics but definitely not: bats, aeroplanes
  - Have an argument over: dinosaurs

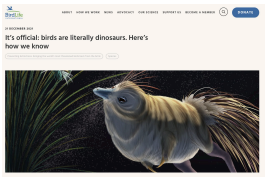


FIGURE 16 BirdLife International, 21 December 2021



FIGURE 17 A velociraptor drawn as a scaly reptile, in the style of older reconstructions



FIGURE 18 A velociraptor restored with feathers, in the style of current reconstructions

13 Follow-up

- This week, you should look under the *Meaning* heading in the online reading list (on Moodle) and sample a few introductory chapters from books on semantics.
- If you have questions, talk to your tutor or do please come see me (email me for a time!).